

129. Harpagus then, seeing him a prisoner, came near, and exulted over him with many gibes and jeers. Among other cutting speeches which he made, he alluded to the supper where the flesh of his son was given him to eat, and asked Astyages to answer *him* now, how he enjoyed being a slave instead of a king? Astyages looked in his face, and asked him in return, why he claimed as his own the achievements of Cyrus? "Because," said Harpagus, "it was my letter which made him revolt, and so I am entitled to all the credit of the enterprise." Then Astyages declared, that "in that case he was at once the silliest and the most unjust of men: the silliest, if when it was in his power to put the crown on his own head, as it must assuredly have been, if the revolt was entirely his doing, he had placed it on the head of another; the most unjust, if on account of that supper he had brought slavery on the Medes. For, supposing that he was obliged to invest another with the kingly power, and not retain it himself, yet justice required that a Mede, rather than a Persian, should receive the dignity. Now, however, the Medes, who had been no parties to the wrong of which he complained, were made slaves instead of lords, and slaves moreover of those who till recently had been their subjects."

130. Thus after a reign of thirty-five years, Astyages lost his crown, and the Medes, in consequence of his cruelty, were brought under the rule of the Persians. Their empire over the parts of Asia beyond the Halys had lasted one hundred and twenty-eight years, except during the time when the Scythians had the dominion.⁹ Afterwards the Medes repented of their

Astyages fled. The provinces fell off, and acknowledged the sovereignty of Persia. Finally Cyrus went in pursuit of Astyages, who had still a small body of adherents, defeated him, and took him prisoner. This last would seem to be the second battle of Herodotus. The last but one is called by Strabo the final struggle, as indeed in one sense it was. It is this which he says took place near Pasargadæ.

The narrative of Plutarch (*De Virtut. Mulier.* p. 246, A.) belongs to the fourth battle, and doubtless came from Ctesias.

As there is less improbability, and far less poetry, in the narrative of Nicolaüs Damascenus than in that of Herodotus, it is perhaps to be preferred, notwithstanding the untrustworthiness of Ctesias, probably his sole authority.

⁹ This is a passage of extreme difficulty. The clause *παρὲς ἢ ὅσον οἱ Σκύθαι ἤρχον*, has been generally understood to mean, "*besides* the time that the Scythians had the dominion;" so that the entire number of years has been supposed to be (128 + 28 =) 156, and Herodotus has thus been considered to place the commencement of the Median hegemony six years before the accession of Deioces. (See the synopsis of the opinions on the passage in Clinton, F. H. vol. i. pp. 257-9; and *infra*, Essay iii. § 13). But *παρὲς ἢ* seems rightly explained by Valckenaer and Clinton as, not "*besides*," but "*except*." "The Medes ruled over Upper Asia 128 years, except during the time that Scythians had the dominion;" *i. e.* they ruled (128 - 28 =) 100 years. (See on this point the '*Rerum Assyriarum tempora emendata*' of

submission, and revolted from Darius, but were defeated in battle, and again reduced to subjection.¹ Now, however, in the time of Astyages, it was the Persians who under Cyrus revolted from the Medes, and became thenceforth the rulers of Asia. Cyrus kept Astyages at his court during the remainder of his life, without doing him any further injury. Such then were the circumstances of the birth and bringing up of Cyrus, and such were the steps by which he mounted the throne. It was at a later date that he was attacked by Croesus, and overthrew him, as I have related in an earlier portion of this history. The overthrow of Croesus made him master of the whole of Asia.

131. The customs which I know the Persians to observe are the following. They have no images of the gods, no temples nor altars, and consider the use of them a sign of folly.²

Dr. Brandis, pp. 6-8.) This would make their rule begin in the twenty-third year of Darius.

Niebuhr (Denkschrift d. Berl. Ac. d. Wissenschaft, 1820-1, pp. 49-50) suspected that the passage was corrupt, and proposed the following reading—*ἄρξαντες τῆς ἀγῶν Ἀλφειοῦ ποταμοῦ Ἀσίης ἐπὶ ἔτεα πεντήκοντα καὶ ἑκατὸν, παρὲς ἣ ὅσον οἱ Σκύθαι ἤρχον, τριήκοντα δυνάμειοντα*. This would remove some, but not all, of the difficulties. It is moreover too extensive an alteration to be received against the authority of all the MSS.

¹ It has been usual to regard this outbreak as identical with the revolt recorded by Xenophon (Hell. i. ii. ad fin.) in almost the same words. Bähr (in loc.) and Dahlmann (Life of Herod. p. 33, Engl. Tr.) have argued from the passage that Herodotus was still employed upon his history as late as B. C. 407. Clinton is of the same opinion, except that he places the revolt one year earlier (F. H. vol. ii. p. 87. Ol. 92, 4). Mr. Grote, with his usual sagacity, perceived that Herodotus could not intend a revolt 150 years after the subjection, or mean by Darius "without any adjective designation," any other Darius than the son of Hystaspes. He saw, therefore, that there must have been a revolt of the Medes from Darius Hystaspes, of which this passage was possibly the only record (Hist. of Greece, vol. iv. p. 304, note). Apparently he was not aware of the great inscription of Darius at Behistun, which had been published by Col. Rawlinson the year before his fourth volume appeared, wherein a long and elaborate account is given of a Median revolt which occurred in the third year of the reign of Darius, and was put down with difficulty. Col. Rawlinson gives the general outline of the struggle as follows:—

"A civil war of a far more formidable character broke out to the northward. Media, Assyria, and Armenia, appear to have been confederated in a bold attempt to recover their independence. They elevated to the throne a descendant, real or supposed, of the ancient line of [Median] kings; and after six actions had been fought between the partisans of this powerful chief and the troops which were employed by Darius, under the command of three of his most distinguished generals, unfavourably it must be presumed to the latter, or at any rate with a very partial and equivocal success, the monarch found himself compelled to repair in person to the scene of conflict. Darius accordingly, in the third year of his reign, re-ascended from Babylon to Media. He brought his enemy to action without delay, defeated and pursued him, and taking him prisoner at Rhages, he slew him in the citadel of Ecbatana" (Behist. Inscript. vol. i. pp. 188-9).

Col. Mure, I observe, though aware of this discovery, maintains the view of Bähr and Dahlmann (Literature of Greece, vol. iv. App. G.), but not, I think, successfully.

² On the general subject of the religion of the Persians, see the Essays appended to this volume, Essay v.

This comes, I think, from their not believing the gods to have the same nature with men, as the Greeks imagine. Their wont, however, is to ascend the summits of the loftiest mountains, and there to offer sacrifice to Jupiter, which is the name they give to the whole circuit of the firmament. They likewise offer to the sun and moon, to the earth, to fire, to water, and to the winds. These are the only gods whose worship has come down to them from ancient times. At a later period they began the worship of Urania, which they borrowed³ from the Arabians and Assyrians. Mylitta is the name by which the Assyrians

³ The readiness of the Persians to adopt foreign customs, even in religion, is very remarkable. Perhaps the most striking instance is the adoption from the Assyrians of the well-known emblem figured below (Figs. 1, 2, 3), consisting of a winged circle, with or without a human figure rising from the circular space. This emblem is of Assyrian origin, appearing in the earliest sculptures of that country (Layard's *Nineveh*, vol. i. ch. v.). Its exact meaning is uncertain, but the conjecture is probable, that while in the human head we have the symbol of intelligence, the wings signify omnipresence, and the circle eternity. Thus the Persians were able, without the sacrifice of any principle, to admit it as a religious emblem, which we find them to have done, as early as the time of Darius, *universally* (see the sculptures at Persepolis, Nakhsh-i-Rustam, Behistun, &c.). It is quite a mistake to conclude from this, as Mr. Layard does (*Nineveh*, vol. ii. ch. vii.), that they adopted the Assyrian religion generally. The monuments prove the very contrary; for, with three exceptions, that of the symbol in question, that of the four-winged genius, and that of the colossal winged bulls, the Assyrian religious emblems do not re-appear in the early Persian sculptures.



Fig. 1.



Fig. 2.



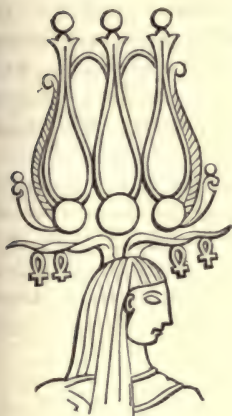
Fig. 3.



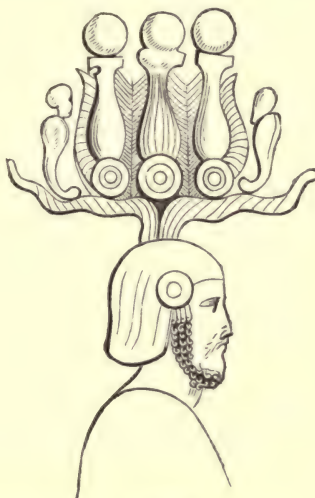
Fig. 4.

A triple figure is sometimes found issuing from the circle (Fig. 4), which has been supposed to represent a triune god, but this mode of representation does not occur in the Persian sculptures. Some religious emblems seem to have been adopted by the Persians from the Egyptians; as, for instance, the curious head-dress of the four-winged genius at *Murg-aur* (Pasargadæ), which closely resembles a well-known Egyptian form. The Persian sculpture is of the time of Cyrus.

know this goddess,⁴ whom the Arabians call Alitta,⁵ and the Persians Mitra.⁶



1. Egyptian.



2. Persian.

⁴ For a full notice of this goddess, see below, Essay x. 'On the Religion of the Assyrians and Babylonians.' The true explanation of the Herodotean nomenclature, which has been so much discussed, seems to be, that Molis (as Nic. Damasc. gives the name, *Fragm. Hist. Gr.*, vol. iii. p. 361, note 16) is for *Volis*, and that *Volis* is identical with the Chaldean *Gula*, the *g* and *v* being (as is well known) perpetually liable to confusion in the Greek orthography of Oriental names. In *Mylitta* we probably have the same name with a feminine ending. *Gula* in the primitive language of Babylonia, which is now ascertained to be of the Hamitic, and not of the Semitic family, signified "great," being either identical with *Gal* (the more ordinary term for "great"—compare *Ner-gal*, *Ṣad-gal*, *Gallus*, &c.), or a feminine form of that word,—answering in fact to the *Guda* of the Galla dialect of Africa. *Gula* is the standard name for the *Great Goddess* throughout the Inscriptions. *Bilat*, or *Beltis*, simply meaning "a lady or mistress," was probably an Assyrian epithet for the same goddess; but if the name were translated by the Assyrians, as was usually the case with the old Hamitic denominations, the equivalent would have been *Rabbat*, as in Syriac it was *Gadlat*, and in Persian *Maha Bag*, which latter compound was contracted to *Mabog*, as the name of the seat of the Great Goddess's worship at Hierapolis. *Gula*, or the Great Goddess, is quite distinct from *Ishtar* or *Astarté*.—[H. C. R.]



Mylitta, the "Great Goddess" of the Assyrians.
(From Layard.)

⁵ Alitta, or Alilat (iii. 8), is the Semitic root אל, "God," with the feminine suffix, ת, or ית, added.

⁶ This identification is altogether a mistake. The Persians, like their Vedio

132. To these gods the Persians offer sacrifice in the following manner : they raise no altar, light no fire, pour no libations, there is no sound of the flute, no putting on of chaplets, no consecrated barley-cake ; but the man who wishes to sacrifice brings his victim to a spot of ground which is pure from pollution, and there calls upon the name of the god to whom he intends to offer. It is usual to have the turban encircled with a wreath, most commonly of myrtle. The sacrificer is not allowed to pray for blessings on himself alone, but he prays for the welfare of the king, and of the whole Persian people, among whom he is of necessity included. He cuts the victim in pieces, and having boiled the flesh, he lays it out upon the tenderest herbage that he can find, trefoil especially. When all is ready, one of the Magi comes forward and chants a hymn, which they say recounts the origin of the gods. It is not lawful to offer sacrifice unless there is a Magus present. After waiting a short time the sacrificer carries the flesh of the victim away with him, and makes whatever use of it he may please.⁷

brethren, worshipped the sun under the name of Mithra. This was a portion of the religion which they brought with them from the Indus, and was not adopted from any foreign nation. The name of Mithra does not indeed occur in the Achæmenian inscriptions until the time of Artaxerxes Mnemon (*Journal of Asiatic Society*, vol. xv. part. i. p. 160), but there is no reason to question the antiquity of his worship in Persia. Xenophon is right in making it a part of the religion of Cyrus (*Cyrop.* viii. iii. § 12, and vii. § 3).

The mistake of Herodotus does not appear to have been discovered by the Greeks before the time of Alexander. Xenophon, indeed, mentions Mithras (*Cyrop.* vii. v. § 53 ; *Econ.* iv. 24), and also the Persian sun-worship (*Cyrop.* viii. iii. § 12), but he does not in any way connect the two. Strabo is the first classical writer who distinctly lays it down that the Persian Mithras is the Sun-god (xv. p. 1039). After him Plutarch shows acquaintance with the fact (*Vit. Alex.* c. 30), which thenceforth becomes generally recognised. (See the inscriptions on altars, *DEO SOLI INVICTO MITHRÆ*, &c., and cf. Suidas, Hesychius, &c.)

The real representative of Venus in the later Pantheon of Persia was Tanata or Anaitis (see Hyde, *De Religione Vet. Pers.* p. 98). Her worship by the Persians had, no doubt, commenced in the time of Herodotus, but it was not till the reign of Artaxerxes Mnemon (B. C. 405 at the earliest) that her statue was set up publicly in the temples of the chief cities of the empire (*Plut. Artaxerx.* c. 27). The inscription of Mnemon recently discovered at Susa records this event (*Journal of Asiatic Soc.*, l. s. c.), which seems to have been wrongly ascribed by Berosus to Artaxerxes Ochus (*Beros. ap. Clem. Alex. Protr.* i. 5).

⁷ At the secret meetings of the Ali Allahis of Persia, which in popular belief have attained an infamous notoriety, but which are in reality altogether innocent, are practised many ceremonies that bear a striking resemblance to the old Magian sacrifice.

The *Peer* or holy man who presides carries about him sprigs both of myrtle and of the musk willow ; he seats his disciples in a circle upon the grass usually in one of those sacred groves with which the Kurdish mountains abound ; he chaunts mystical lays regarding the nature, the attributes, and the manifestations of the Godhead. A sheep is slaughtered as an expiatory sacrifice, and the carcase is boiled upon the spot ; the bones are carefully extracted, and the peer then distributes the flesh among his disciples, who creep up upon their knees from their respective

133. Of all the days in the year, the one which they celebrate most is their birthday. It is customary to have the board furnished on that day with an ampler supply than common. The richer Persians cause an ox, a horse, a camel, and an ass to be baked whole⁸ and so served up to them: the poorer classes use instead the smaller kinds of cattle. They eat little solid food but abundance of dessert, which is set on table a few dishes at a time; this it is which makes them say that "the Greeks, when they eat, leave off hungry, having nothing worth mention served up to them after the meats; whereas, if they had more put before them, they would not stop eating." They are very fond of wine, and drink it in large quantities.⁹ To vomit or obey natural calls in the presence of another, is forbidden among them. Such are their customs in these matters.

It is also their general practice to deliberate upon affairs of weight when they are drunk; and then on the morrow, when they are sober, the decision to which they came the night before is put before them by the master of the house in which it was made; and if it is then approved of, they act on it; if not, they set it aside. Sometimes, however, they are sober at their first deliberation, but in this case they always reconsider the matter under the influence of wine.¹

places in the circle to receive the share allotted to them, which is further accompanied by a blessing and a prayer. It is only the initiated who are admitted to these meetings, and care is taken to guard against the intrusion of strangers and Mohammedans. It is probably, indeed, owing to the precaution which the Ali Allahis take to extinguish their lights on the approach of strangers that they have acquired the name of *Cheragh kushan*, or "lamp-extinguishers," and that orgies have been assigned to them which were only suited to darkness. A disciple, I may add, upon entering the brotherhood, breaks a nutmeg with the spiritual teacher to whom he attaches himself, and wears perpetually about him in token of his dependence, the half of the nut which remains with him; he is called *sir supurdeh*, or "he who has given over his head," and is bound during his noviciate implicitly to follow the behests of his leader. After a probationary discipline of several years, never less than three, he is admitted to a meeting, resigns his nutmeg, partakes of the sacrifice, and henceforward assumes a place among the initiated.—[H. C. R.]

⁸ It is a common custom in the East, at the present day, to roast sheep whole, even for an ordinary repast; and on fête days it is done in Dalmatia and in other parts of Europe.—[G. W.]

⁹ At the present day, among the "bons vivants" of Persia, it is usual to sit for hours before dinner drinking wine and eating dried fruits, such as filberts, almonds, pistachio-nuts, melon-seeds, &c. A party, indeed, often sits down at seven o'clock, and the dinner is not brought in till eleven. The dessert dishes, intermingled as they are with highly-seasoned delicacies, are supposed to have the effect of stimulating the appetite, but, in reality, the solid dishes, which are served up at the end of the feast, are rarely tasted. The passion, too, for wine-drinking is as marked among the Persians of the present day, notwithstanding the prohibitions of the Prophet, as it was in the time of Herodotus. It is quite appalling, indeed, to see the quantity of liquor which some of these toppers habitually consume, and they usually prefer spirits to wine.—[H. C. R.]

¹ Tacitus asserts that the Germans were in the habit of deliberating on peace

134. When they meet each other in the streets, you may know if the persons meeting are of equal rank by the following token ; if they are, instead of speaking, they kiss each other on the lips. In the case where one is a little inferior to the other, the kiss is given on the cheek ; where the difference of rank is great, the inferior prostrates himself upon the ground.² Of nations, they honour most their nearest neighbours whom they esteem next to themselves ; those who live beyond these they honour in the second degree ; and so with the remainder, the further they are removed, the less the esteem in which they hold them. The reason is, that they look upon themselves as very greatly superior in all respects to the rest of mankind, regarding others as approaching to excellence in proportion as they dwell nearer to them ;³ whence it comes to pass that those who are the farthest off must be the most degraded of mankind.⁴ Under the dominion of the Medes, the several nations of the empire exer-

and war under the influence of wine, reserving their determination for the morrow. He gives the reasons for the practice, of which he manifestly approves :—"De pace denique et bello plerumque in conviviis consultant, tanquam nullo magis tempore ad magnas cogitationes incalescat animus. Gens non astuta, nec callida, aperit adhuc secreta pectoris, licentiâ joci. Ergò detecta et nuda omnium mens, posterâ die retractatur ; et salva utriusque temporis ratio est. Deliberant, dum fingere nesciunt : constituunt, dum errare non possunt."—(Germ. 22.) It does not appear that the Germans reversed the process.

Plato, in his *Laws*, mentions the use made of drunkenness by the Persians. He says, the same practice obtained among the Thracians, the Scythians, the Celts, the Iberians, and the Carthaginians (*Book 1. p. 637, E*). Duris of Samos declared that once a year, at the feast of Mithras, the king of Persia was bound to be drunk. (*Fr. 13.*)

² The Persians are still notorious for their rigid attention to ceremonial and etiquette. In all the ordinary pursuits of life, paying visits, entering a room, seating oneself in company, in epistolary address, and even in conversational idiom, gradations of rank are defined with equal strictness and nicety. With regard to the method of salutation, the extreme limits are, as Herodotus observes, the mutual embrace (the kiss is now invariably given on the cheek), and prostration on the ground ; but there are also several intermediate forms, which he has not thought it worth while to notice, of obeisance, kissing hands, &c., by which an experienced observer learns the exact relation of the parties.—[H. C. R.]

³ Of late years, since the nations of Europe have been brought by their commercial and political relations into closer connection with Persia, the excessive vanity and self-admiration of these Frenchmen of the East has been somewhat abated. Their monarch, however, still retains the title of "the Centre of the Universe," and it is not easy to persuade a native of Isfahan that any European capital can be superior to his native city.—[H. C. R.]

⁴ In an early stage of geographical knowledge each nation regards itself as occupying the centre of the earth. Herodotus tacitly assumes that Greece is the centre by his theory of *ἐσχάραι* or "extremities" (iii. 115). Such was the view commonly entertained among the Greeks, and Delphi, as the centre of Greece, was called "the navel of the world" (*γᾶς ὀμφαλός*, Soph. *Œd. T.* 898 ; Pind. *Pyth.* vi. 3, &c.). Even Aristotle expresses himself to the same effect, and regards the happy temperament of the Greeks as the result of their intermediate position (*Polit.* vii. 6). Our own use of the terms "*the East*," "*the West*," is a trace of the former existence of similar views among ourselves.

cised authority over each other in this order. The Medes were lords over all, and governed the nations upon their borders, who in their turn governed the States beyond, who likewise bore rule over the nations which adjoined on them.⁵ And this is the order which the Persians also follow in their distribution of honour; for that people, like the Medes, has a progressive scale of administration and government.

135. There is no nation which so readily adopts foreign customs as the Persians. Thus, they have taken the dress of the Medes,⁶ considering it superior to their own; and in war they

⁵ It is quite inconceivable that there should have been any such system of government, either in Media or Persia, as Herodotus here indicates. With respect to Persia, we know that the most distant satrapies were held as directly of the crown as the nearest. Compare the stories of Orætes (iii. 126-8) and Aryandes (iv. 166). The utmost that can be said with truth is, that in the Persian and Median, as in the Roman empire, there were *three* grades; first, the ruling nation; secondly, the conquered provinces; thirdly, the nations on the frontier, governed by their own laws and princes, but owning the supremacy of the imperial power, and reckoned among its tributaries. This was the position in which the Ethiopians, Colchians, and Arabians, stood to Persia (Herod. iii. 97).

⁶ It appears from ch. 71 that the old national dress of the Persians was a close-fitting tunic and trousers of leather. The Median costume, according to Xenophon (Cyrop. viii. i. § 40) was of a nature to conceal the form, and give it an appearance of grandeur and elegance. It would seem therefore to have been a flowing robe. At Persepolis and Behistun the representations of the monarch and his chief attend-



A. (Median.)



B. (Persian.)

wear the Egyptian breastplate.⁷ As soon as they hear of any luxury, they instantly make it their own: and hence, among other novelties, they have learnt unnatural lust from the Greeks. Each of them has several wives, and a still larger number of concubines.

136. Next to prowess in arms, it is regarded as the greatest proof of manly excellence, to be the father of many sons.⁸ Every year the king sends rich gifts to the man who can show the largest number: for they hold that number is strength. Their sons are carefully instructed from their fifth to their twentieth year,⁹ in three things alone,—to ride, to draw the bow, and to speak the truth.¹⁰ Until their fifth year they are not allowed to come into the sight of their father, but pass their lives with the women. This is done that, if the child die young, the father may not be afflicted by its loss.

ants have invariably a long flowing robe (A), while soldiers and persons of minor importance wear a close-fitting dress, fastened by a belt, and trousers meeting at the ancles a high shoe (B). It seems probable that the costume (A) is that which Herodotus and Xenophon call the Median, while the close-fitting dress (B) is the old Persian garb.

⁷ The Egyptian corslets are noticed again (ii. 182, and vii. 89). For a description of them, see Sir G. Wilkinson's note to Book ii. ch. 182.

⁸ Sheikh Ali Mirza, a son of the well-known Futeh Ali Shah, was accounted the proudest and happiest man in the empire, because, when he rode out on state occasions, he was attended by a body-guard of sixty of his own sons. At the time of Futeh Ali Shah's death his direct descendants amounted to nearly three thousand, some of them being in the fifth degree, and every Persian in consequence felt a pride in being the subject of such a king. The greatest misfortune, indeed, that can befall a man in Persia is to be childless. When a chief's "*hearthstone*," as it was said, "*was dark*," he lost all respect, and hence arose the now universal practice of adoption.—[H. C. R.]

⁹ Xenophon, in his romance (Cyrop. i. ii. § 8), makes the first period of education end with the sixteenth or seventeenth year, after which he says there followed a second period of ten years. It was not till the completion of this second period that the Persian became a full citizen (τέλειος). In all this, it is evident, we have only the philosophic notions of the Greeks. Perhaps even in Herodotus we have Greek speculations rather than history. He does not appear to have travelled in Persia Proper.

¹⁰ The Persian regard for truth has been questioned by Larcher on the strength of the speech of Darius in Book iii. (ch. 72). This speech, however, is entirely unhistoric. The special estimation in which truth was held among the Persians is evidenced in a remarkable manner by the inscriptions of Darius, where *lying* is taken as the representative of all evil. It is the great calamity of the usurpation of the pseudo-Smerdis, that "then the *lie* became abounding in the land" (Behist. Ins. Col. i. Par. 10). "The Evil One (?) invented *lies* that they should deceive the state" (Col. iv. Par. 4). Darius is favoured by Ormazd, "because he was not a heretic, nor a *liar*, nor a tyrant" (Col. iv. Par. 13). His successors are exhorted not to cherish, but to cast into utter perdition, "the man who may be a *liar*, or who may be an evil doer" (ib. Par. 14). His great fear is lest it may be thought that any part of the record which he has set up has been "*falsely* related," and he even abstains from narrating certain events of his reign "lest to him who may hereafter peruse the tablet, the many deeds that have been done by him may seem to be *falsely* recorded" (ib. Par. 6 and 8).

137. To my mind it is a wise rule, as also is the following—that the king shall not put any one to death for a single fault, and that none of the Persians shall visit a single fault in a slave with any extreme penalty ; but in every case the services of the offender shall be set against his misdoings ; and, if the latter be found to outweigh the former, the aggrieved party shall then proceed to punishment.¹

138. The Persians maintain that never yet did any one kill his own father or mother ; but in all such cases they are quite sure that, if matters were sifted to the bottom, it would be found that the child was either a changeling or else the fruit of adultery ; for it is not likely they say that the real father should perish by the hands of his child.

139. They hold it unlawful to talk of any thing which it is unlawful to do. The most disgraceful thing in the world, they think, is to tell a lie ; the next worse, to owe a debt : because, among other reasons, the debtor is obliged to tell lies. If a Persian has the leprosy² he is not allowed to enter into a city, or to have any dealings with the other Persians ; he must, they say, have sinned against the sun. Foreigners attacked by this disorder, are forced to leave the country : even white pigeons are often driven away, as guilty of the same offence. They never defile a river with the secretions of their bodies, nor even wash their hands in one ; nor will they allow others to do so, as they have a great reverence for rivers. There is another peculiarity, which the Persians themselves have never noticed, but which has not escaped my observation. Their names, which are expressive of some bodily or mental excellence,³ all end with the same letter—the letter which is called San by the Dorians, and Sigma

¹ Vide *infra*, vii. 194.

² In the original, two kinds of leprosy are mentioned, the λέπρα and the λεύκη. There does not appear by the description which Aristotle gives of the latter (*Hist. Animal.* iii. 11) to have been any essential difference between them. The λεύκη was merely a mild form of leprosy. With the Persian isolation of the leper, compare the Jewish practice (*Lev.* xiii. 46. *2 Kings* vii. 3. xv. 5. *Luke* xvii. 12).

³ It is apparent from this passage that Herodotus had not any very exact acquaintance with the Persian language ; for though it is true enough the Persian names have all a meaning (as the Greek names also have), yet it is rarely that the etymology can be traced to denote physical or mental qualities. They more usually indicate a glorious or elevated station, or dependance on the gods, or worldly possessions. See the list of Persian names occurring in Herodotus and other writers in the notes appended to Book vi.—[H. C. R.]

⁴ The Phœnician alphabet, from which the Greeks adopted theirs (*infra*, v. 58), possessed both *san* (Heb. *shin*) and *sigma* (Heb. *samech*). The Greeks, not having the sound of *sh*, did not need the two sibilants, and therefore soon merged them in one, retaining however both in their system of numeration, till they replaced *sigma* by *xi*. The Dorians called the sibilant which was kept *san*, the Ionians *sigma*, but the latter use prevailed. The letter came to be generally known as *sigma*, but at

by the Ionians.⁴ Any one who examines will find that the Persian names, one and all without exception, end with this letter.⁵

140. Thus much I can declare of the Persians with entire certainty, from my own actual knowledge. There is another custom which is spoken of with reserve, and not openly, concerning their dead. It is said that the body of a male Persian is never buried, until it has been torn either by a dog or a bird of prey.⁶ That the Magi have this custom is beyond a doubt, for they practise it without any concealment. The dead bodies are covered with wax, and then buried in the ground.

The Magi are a very peculiar race, differing entirely from the Egyptian priests, and indeed from all other men whatsoever. The Egyptian priests make it a point of religion not to kill any live animals except those which they offer in sacrifice. The Magi, on the contrary, kill animals of all kinds with their own hands, excepting dogs⁷ and men. They even seem to take a delight in the employment, and kill, as readily as they do other animals, ants and snakes, and such like flying or creeping things. However, since this has always been their custom, let them keep to it. I return to my former narrative.

141. Immediately after the conquest of Lydia by the Persians, the Ionian and Æolian Greeks sent ambassadors to Cyrus at Sardis, and prayed to become his lieges on the footing which

the same time it held the place of *san* in the alphabet. (See Bunsen's Philosophy of Univ. Hist. vol. I. p. 258.)

⁶ Here Herodotus was again mistaken. The Persian names of men which terminate with a consonant end indeed invariably with the letter *s*, or rather *sh*, as *Kurúsh* (Cyrus), *Dáryavush* (Darius), *Chishpáish* (Teispes), *Hakhámanish*, &c. (Achæmenes). [The *sh* in such cases is the mere nominative ending of the 2nd and 3rd declensions; *i. e.* of themes ending in *i* and *u*.—H. C. R.] But a large number of Persian names of men were pronounced with a vowel termination, not expressed in writing, and in these the last consonant might be almost any letter. We find on the monuments *Vashtásp(a)* Hystaspes—*Arshám(a)* Arsames—*Ariyáráman(a)* Ariaramnes—*Bardi(a)* Bardius or Smerdis—*Gaumát(a)* Gomates—*Gaubru(a)* Gobryas—&c. &c. The *sigma* in these cases is a mere conventional addition of the Greeks.

⁶ Agathias (ii. p. 60) and Strabo (xv. p. 1042) also mention this strange custom, which still prevails among the Parsees wherever they are found, whether in Persia or in India. Chardin relates that there was in his time a cemetery, half a league from Isfahán, consisting of a round tower 35 feet high, without any doorway or other entrance. Here the Guebres deposited their dead by means of a ladder, and left them to be devoured by the crows, which were to be seen in large numbers about the place. (Voyage en Perse, tom. ii. p. 186.) Such towers exist throughout India, wherever the Parsees are numerous. The bodies are laid on iron bars sloping inwards. When the flesh is gone, the bones slip through between the bars, or sliding down them fall in at the centre, where there is an open space left for the purpose.

⁷ The dog is represented in the Zendavesta as the special animal of Ormazd, and is still regarded with peculiar reverence by the Parsees. On one of the magnificent tombs at the Chehl-Minâr, of which Chardin has given an accurate drawing (plate 68), a row of dogs is the ornament of the entablature.

they had occupied under Crœsus. Cyrus listened attentively to their proposals, and answered them by a fable. "There was a certain piper," he said, "who was walking one day by the sea-side, when he espied some fish; so he began to pipe to them, imagining they would come out to him upon the land. But as he found at last that his hope was vain, he took a net, and enclosing a great draught of fishes, drew them ashore. The fish then began to leap and dance; but the piper said, 'Cease your dancing now, as you did not choose to come and dance when I piped to you.'" Cyrus gave this answer to the Ionians and Æolians, because, when he urged them by his messengers to revolt from Crœsus, they refused; but now, when his work was done, they came to offer their allegiance. It was in anger, therefore, that he made them this reply. The Ionians, on hearing it, set to work to fortify their towns, and held meetings at the Panionium,^{7a} which were attended by all excepting the Milesians, with whom Cyrus had concluded a separate treaty, by which he allowed them the terms they had formerly obtained from Crœsus. The other Ionians resolved, with one accord, to send ambassadors to Sparta to implore assistance.

142. Now the Ionians of Asia, who meet at the Panionium, have built their cities in a region where the air and climate are the most beautiful in the whole world; for no other region is equally blessed with Ionia, neither above it nor below it, nor east nor west of it. For in other countries either the climate is over cold and damp, or else the heat and drought are sorely oppressive. The Ionians do not all speak the same language, but use in different places four different dialects. Towards the south their first city is Miletus, next to which lie Myus and Priêné;⁸

^{7a} *Infra*, ch. 148, note ³.

⁸ Miletus, Myus, and Priêné all lay near the mouth of the Mæander (the modern *Mendere*). At their original colonisation they were all maritime cities. Miletus stood at the northern extremity of a promontory formed by the mountain-range called Grius, commanding the entrance of an extensive bay which washed the base of the four mountains, Grius, Latmus, and Titanus, south of the Mæander, and Mycalé, a continuation of the great range of Messogis, north of that stream. This bay, called the bay of Latmus, was about 25 miles in its greatest length, from near Latmus to Priêné. Its depth, from Miletus to Myus, was above 5 miles. Myus stood nearly in the centre of the bay, at the foot of Titanus; Priêné, at its northern extremity, under the hill of Mycalé. Into this bay the Mæander poured its waters, and the consequence was the perpetual formation of fresh land. (*Vide infra*, ii. 10, where Herodotus notes the fact.) Priêné, by the time of Strabo, was 40 stadia (4½ miles) from the sea (xii. p. 827). Myus had been rendered uninhabitable by the growth of the alluvium, forming hollows in its vicinity, where the stagnant water generated swarms of musquitoes (Strab. xiv. p. 912; Pausan. vii. ii. § 7). Since the time of these geographers the changes have been even more astonishing. The soil brought down by the Mæander has filled up the whole of the northern portion of the gulf, so that Miletus, Myus, and Priêné now stand on the outskirts of a great